15.5 Handler status codes with StatusCodePagesMiddleware

In chapter 4 we discussed error handling middleware, which is designed to catch exceptions generated anywhere in your middleware pipeline, catch them, and generate a user-friendly response. In this section you'll learn about an analogous piece of middleware that intercepts error HTTP status codes: `StatusCodePagesMiddleware`.

Your Razor Pages application can return a wide range of HTTP status codes that indicate some sort of error state. You've seen previously that a `500` "server error" is sent when an exception occurs and isn't handled and that a `404` "file not found" error is sent when you return a `NotFoundResult` from a page handler. `404` errors are particularly common, often occurring when a user enters an invalid URL.

TIP `404` errors are often used to indicate that a specific requested object was not found. For example, a request for the details of a product with an ID of `23` might return a `404` if no such product exists. They're also generated automatically if no endpoint in your application matches the request URL.

Returning "raw" status codes without additional content is generally OK if you're building a minimal API or web API application. But as mentioned before, for apps consumed directly by users such as Razor Pages apps, this can result in a poor user experience. If you don't handle these status codes, users will see a generic error page, as you saw in figure 15.4, which may leave many confused users thinking your application is broken. A better approach is to handle these error codes and return an error page that's in keeping with the rest of your application or at least doesn't make your application look broken.